

Life After Sarcoma

A Survivorship Guide for Patients and Families

Understanding follow-up care, managing late effects, returning to work, emotional recovery, and living well beyond sarcoma treatment.

Sarcoma Hub | Survivorship Series | Document 6 of 6
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You Have Finished Treatment — What Now?

Completing active sarcoma treatment is a significant milestone, but it can also bring unexpected emotions — relief mixed with anxiety, uncertainty, or grief. Many survivors describe a sense of being 'set adrift' when the structure of treatment appointments ends. This is completely normal, and it is why survivorship care matters.

KEY FACT: Sarcoma survivors require long-term follow-up — typically for a minimum of 5-10 years. This is not because cure is unlikely, but because sarcomas can recur late and because some treatment side effects emerge years after treatment ends.

Your Follow-up Schedule

Follow-up frequency and content depends on your sarcoma subtype, grade, stage, and treatment. In general, most sarcoma follow-up protocols follow a pattern like this:

Period	Frequency	Typical Content
Year 1-2	Every 3 months	Clinical review + CT/MRI of primary site + chest CT for lung surveillance
Year 3-4	Every 4-6 months	Clinical review + imaging (frequency may reduce based on risk)
Year 5	Every 6 months	Clinical review + imaging
Year 6-10	Annually	Clinical review + imaging (for high-grade subtypes)
Beyond 10 years	Annually	Late effects monitoring; cardiac screening; bone health

IMPORTANT: These are general guidelines only. Your oncologist will give you a personalised follow-up plan. Never miss a scheduled scan or appointment — catching a recurrence early significantly improves outcomes.

Understanding Late Effects of Treatment

Some side effects of sarcoma treatment do not appear until months or years after treatment ends. Being aware of these helps you report symptoms promptly and access monitoring and support:

Late Effect	What to know and do
Cardiac effects (doxorubicin)	Cardiomyopathy (weakening of the heart muscle) can develop years after doxorubicin-based chemotherapy. Regular cardiac monitoring (echocardiogram) is recommended. Report any breathlessness, ankle swelling, or reduced exercise tolerance.
Peripheral neuropathy (ifosfamide/cisplatin)	Numbness, tingling, or weakness in hands and feet. Usually improves after treatment but may persist. Physiotherapy can help with balance and function.
Bone health (radiation / steroids)	Radiation to bone increases fracture risk. Long-term steroids and some chemotherapy agents cause osteoporosis. DEXA bone density scans and vitamin D supplementation are often recommended.
Lymphoedema (after lymph node surgery or radiation)	Permanent swelling, usually in a limb. A specialist lymphoedema physiotherapist can provide compression garments and manual drainage.
Secondary cancers (radiation)	Radiation therapy very rarely causes a new cancer in the treatment field, typically 10-20 years later. This risk is small but is a reason for long-term follow-up.
Fertility effects (chemotherapy / radiation)	Some chemotherapy agents (especially alkylating agents like ifosfamide) and pelvic radiation reduce fertility. Discuss referral to a fertility specialist if relevant.
Psychological effects (PTSD, anxiety, depression)	Cancer trauma is real. Post-traumatic stress disorder affects a significant minority of cancer survivors. Psychological support is available and effective.
Fatigue	Cancer-related fatigue can persist for months or years after treatment. Graded exercise therapy, sleep hygiene, and psychological support are all evidence-based interventions.

Returning to Work and Daily Life

Returning to work after sarcoma treatment can be challenging but is an important goal for many survivors. There is no right timeline — it depends on your treatment, your role, and how you feel:

- **Phased return** — most occupational health services support a gradual return to work, starting with reduced hours.
- **Know your rights** — in the US, the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) requires employers to provide reasonable accommodations for cancer survivors.
- **Inform your employer** — only share what you are comfortable with, but open communication about your needs is usually beneficial.
- **Fatigue management** — plan your most demanding tasks for your highest-energy periods.
- **Physical roles** — if your work is physical and you have had limb surgery, a physiotherapist and occupational therapist can advise on functional capacity.
- **Financial support** — if you cannot return to your previous role, social workers and patient advocacy organisations can advise on disability benefits and financial assistance.

Emotional Recovery and Mental Health

The emotional impact of a sarcoma diagnosis and treatment does not end when treatment does. Many survivors experience:

- **Scanxiety** — intense anxiety before follow-up scans. Very common and completely understandable. Mindfulness, talking to others who understand, and distraction strategies can help.
- **Grief** — for the life you had before diagnosis, for changes to your body, for relationships affected.
- **Identity shift** — many survivors describe a changed sense of self. Some find this ultimately positive; others need time to adjust.
- **Relationship changes** — cancer affects couples, families, and friendships. Couples counselling or family therapy can be valuable.
- **Post-traumatic growth** — many survivors report increased appreciation for life, stronger relationships, and new priorities. This is a real and well-documented phenomenon.

Help is available. Ask your oncology team for a referral to a psychologist or counsellor who works with cancer patients. CancerCare ([cancercare.org](https://www.cancercare.org)) provides free counselling. The Sarcoma Hub Community Forum connects you with others who truly understand what you have been through.

Living Well: A Survivorship Health Checklist

When	Action
Annually	Attend all scheduled follow-up scans and clinical reviews.
Annually	Cardiac echo if you received doxorubicin-based chemotherapy.
Annually	Bone density (DEXA) scan if at risk of osteoporosis.

Regularly	Gentle, progressive exercise — even walking 30 min/day has significant benefits.
Daily	Nutritious diet rich in protein, vegetables, and whole grains.
Ongoing	Report any new lumps, pains, or unexplained symptoms to your team promptly.
Ongoing	Stay connected — to your medical team, to other survivors, and to your support network.
If needed	Seek psychological support — PTSD, anxiety, and depression are treatable.

You have been through something extraordinary. Whatever your journey ahead, the Sarcoma Hub community is here to support you. Share your story. Help the next patient who sits where you once sat.

This guide is provided for informational purposes only. Individual care should be guided by your medical team. Sarcoma Hub — sarcomahub.org